

THE GREATEST STORY EVER TOLD

TEXT: Luke 2:11-14 (KJV) “*For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, which is Christ the Lord.* ¹² *And this shall be a sign unto you; Ye shall find the babe wrapped in swaddling clothes, lying in a manger.* ¹³ *And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God, and saying,* ¹⁴ *Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will toward men.*”

INTRO: Many stories have been told in the world but the story of the conception, birth, life, death and resurrection of Jesus excels them all.

All of us have a story, and there are many “*Happily ever after*” stories to tell. There are stories made for TV, and there are stories made for the big screen and Broadway.

This story plays out of four hundred silent years between the Old Testament and the New Testament. Out of one of the darkest era's in human history flows the Greatest Story Ever Told! It is the story of the love of God and Jesus His Son!

**THE GREATEST STORY EVER TOLD
INVOLVES A PROPHETIC WORD
THROUGH AN UNLIKELY VESSEL**

Luke 1:18 "The angel said to Zachariah: I am Gabriel, I stand in the presence of God, and I have been sent to speak to you and to tell you this good news. And now you will be silent and not able to speak until the day this happens, because you did not believe my words, which will come true at their appointed time."

One of the most overlooked facts about the Christmas story is the role John the Baptist played in Jesus' first coming. A few months before Christ birth an angel appeared to Zachariah, the uncle of Jesus and announced to

him that he and his wife Elizabeth would be having a son whose name was to be John. Luke 1:11-13 ***“Then an angel of the Lord appeared to him, standing at the right side of the altar of incense. When Zechariah saw him, he was startled and was gripped with fear. But the angel said to him: “Do not be afraid, Zechariah; your prayer has been heard. Your wife Elizabeth will bear you a son, and you are to call him John.”***

An old couple named Zachariah and Elizabeth were barren and could not have children. To make matters worse, they were far past their child bearing years. Yet, the Angel declares that they were going to get pregnant and have a baby. What is impossible with man is no big deal to God.

Though often overlooked, John the Baptist would play a central role in The Greatest Story Ever Told. He would be the person who would

blaze the trail ahead of Jesus and declare Him to be the Son of God.

Zechariah, a priest in the temple in Jerusalem, played a key role in God's plan of salvation because of his righteousness and obedience. When Zechariah and Elizabeth's prayer for a son was finally answered, and in a very dramatic way. Gabriel, the Arch Angel made a personal visit to Zechariah and let him know that he and Elizabeth would not only have a child, but would have a boy who would blaze the trail for Messiah. Luke 1:18 ***"The angel said to Zachariah: I am Gabriel, I stand in the presence of God, and I have been sent to speak to you and to tell you this good news."***

Even though Zechariah and Elizabeth had spent their adult lives petitioning the Lord for a child, Zechariah doubted God's word when it was prophesied to him. I wonder what doubt and unbelief has kept us from receiving and accomplishing?

Zechariah doubted Gabriel's message because of he and Elizabeth's age. Because of his doubt and unbelief, Zechariah was struck with muteness, until the child was born.

Mathew Henry very simply notes, *"His unbelief was silenced. When Zechariah left the Temple, he could not brag about the vision, nor question the prophecy."* Sadly, God often finds it necessary to silence us in order to get a miracle to us. The Children of Israel were silenced for thirteen trips around Jericho because they had spent the last forty-five years talking themselves out of the Promised Land.

Let's take a look at the meaning of the names of Zechariah and Elizabeth's names:

- Zechariah... *"God remembers."*
- Elizabeth... *"God of the Promise."*

When you put their names together their names mean *"God remembers His promise."* What a

deal! Folks with names as powerful as theirs should walk in faith all the time! As we all should!

In Jewish tradition the father held the naming rights. When John was born Zechariah could not speak so his relatives gave him a writing tablet and he wrote, "*His name is John.*"

Upon writing this Zechariah immediately:

- Regained his speech...
- Was filled with the Holy Spirit...
- Prophesied about his son's life...

In his prophecy, Zachariah explains how God remembered all three unconditional covenants in the Old Testament:

1. The covenant with Abraham. Zechariah reminded his listeners of "*The oath he swore to our Father Abraham.*" God promised Abraham

land, descendants and blessing. Genesis 12:1-3
(PLACE SCRIPTURE HERE)

2. The covenant David. Zechariah said, “***He has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David.***”

God promised David that one from his house would sit on his Jerusalem throne reign over an eternal kingdom. 2 Samuel 7:16 (PLACE SCRIPTURE HERE)

3. The new covenant to Israel. God promised Israel a new covenant, one that would replace the Mosaic covenant and that would bring forgiveness of sins. Jeremiah 31:31 Hebrew 8:6–13 (PLACE SCRIPTURES HERE)

Zechariah’s prophecy was a reminder to the people that God had remembered His covenant! He is a covenant keeping God! “***He keeps His covenants to a thousand generations.***”

Zechariah said, “***He has remembered His Holy Covenant.***” Zechariah and Elizabeth’s names mean, “*God remembers His promise.*”

Zacharias and Elizabeth were so old, they likely had given up hope of having a child. Even though hope had long faded from their words and actions, they continued to pray. Prayer without hope is pretty ineffective.

It is interesting that Zechariah’s prophecy was full of reminders about God keeping His promises!!!

CONCLUSION:

Have you been waiting a long time on an answer to your prayers? Have you been holding on to a promise in God’s Word? 2 Peter 3:9
“***The Lord is not slow about His promise, as some count slowness...***”

“***As some count slowness***” refers to those who demand God perform on their timetable and not

His. Remember Gabriel's last line to Zechariah?
***“You did not believe my words, which will
come true AT THEIR APPOINTED TIME.”***

God's delay does not mean He is inactive. He has something special planned. Gods timing is perfect. It may not be the timing we want, but it's the timing we need.

Trust in Him! God always remembers His promise.

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INTRO: Last week we talked about the story of Zechariah and Elizabeth. God often does His best work in out of the way places and uses the most unlikely people.

One thing is for certain, before He brings about a major fulfillment of prophecy, He sends a forerunner as he did with John the Baptist.

THE GREATEST STORY EVER TOLD INVOLVES THE INCARNATION OF CHRIST

Luke 1:26-35 (KJV) *“In the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God unto a city of Galilee, named Nazareth, ²⁷ To a virgin espoused to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David; and the virgin's name was Mary. ²⁸ And the angel came in unto her, and said, Hail, thou that art highly favored, the Lord is with thee: blessed art thou among women. ²⁹ And when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and cast in her mind what manner of salutation this should be. ³⁰ And the angel said unto her, Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God. ³¹ And, behold, thou shalt conceive in thy womb, and bring forth a son, and shalt call his name JESUS. ³² He shall be great, and shall be called the Son of the Highest: and the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: ³³ And he shall reign over the house of Jacob*

for ever; and of his kingdom there shall be no end. ³⁴ Then said Mary unto the angel, How shall this be, seeing I know not a man? ³⁵ And the angel answered and said unto her, The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God.”

Let us take a few moments and place ourselves in Mary’s place. Mary had saved herself for marriage; she was a virgin! She had made the protection of her reputation a very high priority. She had never been with a man and the only way a child had ever been conceived is for a man and a woman to engage in intimate contact.

If the words of the angel were to come to pass, she would lose her reputation and become the object of suspicion, innuendo and gossip.

Think of the questions flooding the mind of Mary:

- How can this be?
- Why am I the one?
- What about Joseph?
- What will people think?
- Who would believe this story?

The words of the angel were over the line of human impossibility! Yet, listen to the admonition of the angel. “***Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favor with God.***” The angel was asking Mary to step into an arena that no human being had ever ventured into in the history of the world! Mary was about to:

- Go off the chain...
- Travel beyond the map...
- Sail into uncharted waters...
- Traverse the limits of human history...
- Test the very limits of human impossibility...

Yet, Gabriel say’s to her, “***The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the***

Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore, also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God.” Notice three very important things:

- The Holy Ghost was to come upon Mary...
- The power of the Highest was to overshadow Mary...
- The Son of God would be the result of the arrangement between Heaven and earth...

Galatians 4:4 (KJV) ***“But when the fullness of time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law.”***

The miracle of the incarnation of Christ is that He was 100% God and 100% man simultaneously.

The ultimate in human impossibility looked like this:

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son was given....

- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the world... (From everlasting to everlasting – Eternal Priesthood after the order – Before Abraham was, I am)
- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...
- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in Bethlehem's stable...
- The Omnipotent became a dependent life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast yourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning)
- He became sin so the sinful could be forgiven...
- He was bruised so we could be healed...
- He endured turmoil so we could have peace...

- He was rejected so we could be accepted...
- He came to earth so we could go to heaven...
- He became hungry so the hungry could be fed...
- He became thirsty so the thirsty could be satisfied...

Think of this:

- On His Mother's side He wept at the tomb of His friend Lazarus, on His Father's side He called Lazarus back to life...
- On His Mother's side it was necessary to maintain hydration, on His Father's side He offered water that would quench thirst for time and eternity...
- On His Mother's side He was thirty years old when He entered public ministry, on His Father's side He was present when the morning stars sang together and the sons of God shouted for joy... (Where was Jesus from 12-30?)

- On His Mother's side He was thirty-three and one-half years old, on His Father's side He was the Ancient of Days...
- On His Mother's side He died an early death, on His Father's side He abolished death...
- On His Mother's side He was buried in a borrowed tomb, on His Father's side He is the resurrection and the life...
- On His Mother's side He was subject to His parents, on His Father's side God gave Him a name above all other names...
- On His Mother's side He rode a donkey or walked everywhere He went. On His Father's side He rides on the wings of the wind...
- On His Mother's side He used a candle to dispel the darkness of night, on His Father's side He lit the world three days before He created the sun, moon and stars...
- On His Mother's side He could not light one room at a time, on His Father's side He will

be the light of a city that is built two thousand miles square...

- On His Mother's side He could only be in one place at a time, on His Father's side He is omnipresent...
- On His Mother's side He had to rely upon the facts He could see, on His Father's side He is omniscient...
- On His Mother's side He broke under the weight of the cross, on His Father's side He is omnipotent...
- On His Mother's side He was a lamb led to His own slaughter, on His Father's side He was the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His Mother's side He did not open His mouth in His own defense, on His Father's side He possessed the power to call twelve legions of angels to His own rescue...
- On His Mother's side He tolerated injustice and aggression, on His Father's side He treads out the wine press of the wrath of God and breaks mighty armies across His knees...

- On His Mother's side He was Jesus, Mary's boy, on His Father's side He is King of Kings and Lord of Lords...
- On His Mother's side He never had his name in lights, on His Father's side He will reign forever...
- On His Mother's side He was never elected to high office, on His Father's side He will rule over Heaven and Earth...
- On His Mother's side He was of no reputation, on His Father's side every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess He is Lord to the glory of God the Father...

Mary faced up to the overwhelming onslaught of human impossibility and gave birth to the Messiah. God anointed Mary to walk the trail of difficulty so that she could experience the reality of the greatest miracle the world would ever know – The incarnation of Jesus.

I can't quite get my mind around the fact that God became one of us, yet I know He did. I am thrilled He did!

CONCLUSION:

Why would God do a thing like this? John 3:16

“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son. That whosoever believeth in Him should not perish, but have everlasting life.”

2 Peter 3:9 (KJV) ***“The Lord is not slack concerning his promise, as some men count slackness; but is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.”***

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INTRO: Week one we talked about where Zechariah, Elizabeth, and John the Baptist fit into the Greatest Story Ever Told.

Last week we talked about the incarnation of Christ. Jesus dawned an earth suit and came and lived among us, as one of us, for 33 ½ years. It is pretty hard to believe that our God would love us that much, but He did and does!

THE GREATEST STORY EVER TOLD INVOLVES THE EARTHLY FAMILY OF JESUS

Luke 3:23 *“He was the son, so it was thought, of Joseph.”*

The genealogy of the earthly family of Jesus is listed in Matthew and Luke.

The one from Matthew is from Joseph’s lineage, which is *“the legal family line”* of Jesus.

The Scripture in Luke covers Mary’s lineage, which is the *“blood-line”* of Jesus.

Think of this: Susan Paul said *“The lineage of Jesus covers the Old Testament Law and New Testament Faith!”*

Anytime I read the story of Jesus birth and lineage, Joseph always stands out to me. Joseph is this quiet person that only gets a few

mentions in the story of our Savior's entrance into the world as the God-man. He is in no way a central character but what an important role he plays in The Greatest Story Ever Told.

Every time I read through this story; I find myself asking questions about Joseph. Because the Bible doesn't record a lot about Him, I am left to fill-in-the-blanks from my sanctified imagination:

I wonder about the relationship between Joseph and Jesus? I would really like to know more about this!

- I wonder if Joseph struggled with his ability to parent this God-man?
- I wonder if Joseph felt worthy to be Mary's husband seeing she gave birth to the Son of God?
- I wonder what Jesus called Joseph? Father? Dad? Joseph? Joe?
- I wonder if Joseph ever gazed into the night sky wondering how he would do it?

Commentaries call Joseph, “*Jesus adoptive father.*”

Adoption is one of my most favorite things in this world. I love the implications in the natural of a set of parents opening their hearts, homes, and treasure to a child who, at least initially, can offer nothing in return. In the spiritual sense the whole concept of adoption goes to an even greater level because the Heavenly Father chose by an act of His own will, to adopt us earthlings!

The message Paul preached to the Romans, about our adoption into the Family of God, is exemplified in Joseph. In fact, adoption is the message of Joseph’s story.

One commentary on made the following observations about the adoption between Joseph and Jesus:

- “*Romans eight tells us that we are adopted into the family of God and that we are joint-*

heirs with Christ. We are God's children and therefore we call Him, 'Abba, or Father.' It would be dishonoring for us to reject our privilege to call God Father after He has so graciously adopted us into His family. The same would have been true for Jesus. Joseph graciously adopted Jesus as his own, and a first-century Jewish child (adopted, step-children, and biological children) called their male parent 'father.' It is reasonable to think that Jesus did the same as a way to honor the man who was chosen by His Heavenly Father to be His earthly father."

Think of that! Jesus trusted who The Father trusted! I wonder how that made Joseph feel? I am sure it was humbling.

God knew He could trust Joseph to be the earthly father to Jesus!

Joseph is first mentioned in Matthew 1:18-25 where he is referred to as a righteous man. A man who did the right thing every time! We should strive for the same kind of right living.

Through several dreams and visits by angels, Joseph received instructions for the safety of his family and direction on where to move, to keep Jesus safe protected. We are the spiritual priests of our households!

Joseph's responsiveness to God shows he was a man of integrity who was willing to do God's will—no matter what. Teaching our children integrity is a very important responsibility of fatherhood.

Joseph trained his son in the trade of carpentry. Can you image the hours they spent together and conversations they might have had? Nothing takes the place of time spent between a father and his children. Fathers should teach their children to work.

Joseph made sure Jesus had spiritual training in Nazareth. He also took the whole family on the yearly trip to Jerusalem for the Passover, which Jesus continued to observe during his adult years. Every father should make sure his family is in church, not regularly but faithfully.

Joseph was appointed by God to name the newborn Christ child. An angel appeared to none other than —Joseph —and told HIM to name the baby that Mary was carrying. The angel said, “*You shall call His name Jesus*” (Matthew 1:21) and, as the Lord’s earthly father, Joseph gave the baby the name of Jesus.

Can you imagine the honor Joseph must have felt being chosen to be in the lineage of Jesus and getting some screen play in The Greatest Story Ever Told?

CONCLUSION:

Think of this:

Each of us have been invited to be a part of The Greatest Story Ever Told as well. Romans 8:16-17 (KJV) *“The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God: ¹⁷ And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ; if so be that we suffer with him, that we may be also glorified together.”* (Message) *“God’s Spirit touches our spirits and confirms who we really are. We know who he is, and we know who we are: Father and children. And we know we are going to get what’s coming to us—an unbelievable inheritance! We go through exactly what Christ goes through. If we go through the hard times with him, then we’re certainly going to go through the good times with him!”*

What does it mean to be in this family line?

We have been adopted into God’s family, so we enjoy all the benefits of the adoptive process and lifestyle... (Have a video of Jake and Amber here)

We are heirs to the God of the universe and co-heirs with His Son Jesus... This means that what belongs to Jesus, belongs to us! Jesus said, ***“All power has been given to me in Heaven and in earth.”*** He also said, ***“I give you power to tread on serpents and scorpions and over ALL the power of the enemy and NOTHING shall by any means hurt you.”***

As His heirs and co-heirs, we have not only the task, but the authority and power to bring Kingdom life into our circles of Influence... We are bringing Heaven to Houston!

Because we are His heirs and co-heirs we will rule and reign with Him for all of time and eternity... ***“You have been faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things.”***